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The Book of the Heart

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Parmenter - Book Profile: Writing the Medieval Self - JCRT 3.2

Writing the Medieval Self

Book Profile: Jager, Eric. *The Book of the Heart*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 2000 (cloth), 2001 (paper). ISBN 0226391175.

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At a time when many literary and cultural theorists are grappling with disembodied subjectivity and the dematerialization of textuality in an electronic age, Eric Jager has taken a step back into the European Middle Ages in order to similarly explore the relationships between psychology and communications technology. *The Book of the Heart* traces metaphors that situate the self in a bookish heart through biblical and patristic literature, popular devotional texts, and secular romances from 400-1500 CE. In this project the author attempts to answer Jacques Derrida's call in *Of Grammatology* to write a history of the metaphor of the ontology of interior writing, "a metaphor that systematically contrasts divine or natural writing and the human and laborious, finite and artificial inscription."¹ But Jager does not wax Derridian in his analysis. Instead, he attempts to show the "relation of ideology or theory to the material conditions of literary culture," (p. xvi) discussing the corporeal forms and practices of reading and writing. Unfortunately *The Book of the Heart* tends to be more descriptive than analytical, but it does provide a useful historical and material context for thinking about the correlation between grammatology, technology, and changing subjectivities.

> He cried out, "Oh, sweet Lord! If only I could devise some love token which would be an ever-

This is worth quoting at length because it gives form to the development that Jager traces from

Notes

Dorina Miller Parmenter is a Ph.D. candidate in the Department of Religion at Syracuse University and teaches part-time at Syracuse University and Cayuga Community College. Prior to attending Syracuse University she received an M.A. in Studio Arts from Ball State University, focusing on bookbinding and metalwork. She is currently investigating how the material contexts of books and readers create both religious subjects and religious objects.

¹Jacques Derrida, *Of Grammatology*, Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak, trans. , Baltimore: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1967/1997, 15.

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